

UNDER THREAT
Tigers at the Tadoba Andhari reserve

AFP

MAHARASHTRA

WHAT'S KILLING MAHA'S TIGERS?

By Dhaval Kulkarni

It's a strange irony. Go by the numbers, and Maharashtra seems endowed with a healthy tiger population. But look closely and you find a large number dying as well. Since 2018, the state has lost 151 tigers, a third of them to unnatural causes. Poaching and electrocution claimed 42 tiger lives, drowning and rail and road accidents killed another 16, a testimony to how linear projects dissecting tiger habitats pose an inherent risk for the big cats.

Till October 26, Maharashtra has seen 36 tiger deaths. Four of these were on account of accidents, one due to poaching via poisoning and eight by electrocution. In 2022, the state lost 29 tigers, of which 18 died natural deaths, four each were lost to accidents and electrocution, and three to poaching. According to the tiger census that year, Maharashtra had an estimated 444 tigers. The state has six tiger reserves: Tadoba Andhari, Pench, Navegaon Nagzira, Bor, Melghat and Sahyadri.

Of all the unnatural causes for tiger mortality, poaching remains the most deleterious. Wildlife conservationists point to emboldened poacher gangs at work. To combat them, they highlight the need for surveillance and protection in buffer areas and translocation corridors to ensure that dispersing tigers are not at risk. Tigers typically disperse, or move, from their natal area to other areas to establish control over territory.

Some big cats unwittingly get caught in electrified fences erected by farmers to keep away herbivores that indulge in crop depredations. Says a retired forest services officer, "Farmers often steal power to electrify farm fences...tigers are often killed due to this." While it is essential that the forest department, police and electricity distribution company stop this practice, electrocution is also a favoured method of poachers to kill tigers. This year itself, there have been several instances of tigers being electrocuted by live traps laid by poachers.

Wildlife conservationist Kedar Gore says that poaching took place where there was tiger dispersal but low surveillance—typically, dispersal corridors. "As numbers rise, tigers will explore newer territories. They are vulnerable during these movements.... Areas other than reserves need better surveillance," Gore explains. That is because poaching is difficult to establish unless a fresh tiger carcass or body parts are recovered. Poachers can well commit the ghastly deed but not leave any evidence.

Then there is the age-old problem of man-animal conflict, due to rising tiger numbers. Sudhir Mungantiwar, Maharashtra minister for forests, says that officials had been asked to launch a public awareness programme and inform locals about tiger presence. In the Tadoba Andhari tiger reserve, the forest department is using newly-launched AI-based e-surveillance to capture thermal images of tigers to alert local villagers. "Our priority is to bring electrocution (of tigers) to zero," says Mungantiwar.

"Tiger deaths in Maharashtra are directly related to their population," says a senior official of the forest department. "If the population of tigers is growing, so will the death rate.... There is nothing alarming about their deaths." He stressed that unnatural deaths were an outcome of saturation in tiger landscapes and growing urbanisation, precipitating man-animal conflict. Over half of Maharashtra's tigers are concentrated in the landscape comprising the Tadoba Andhari tiger project (97 tigers) and the Brahmapuri (66), Chandrapur (52) and Central Chanda (36) forest divisions. This area is interspersed with human habitations and mining and other activities.

The retired officer says that while the situation "was not alarming, it deserves attention". According to him, cases of poaching had fallen since 2007-08, with gangs of poachers from North India keeping away due to increased surveillance. And that is what needs to be sustained. A constant vigil, for tigers to live and roam freely. ■

OF THE 36 TIGER DEATHS IN MAHARASHTRA THIS YEAR, 13 ARE FOR UNNATURAL REASONS